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Swedish municipalities and EU public consultations

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Abstract

The EU Commission's consultations are designed to increase openness, collect expertise, and foster trust in EU institutions. Given that EU public consultations are intended to be open to a wide range of stakeholders, including local authorities, the low level of engagement from Swedish municipalities is puzzling. The aim of this thesis is therefore to examine how Swedish municipalities reason about participation in EU public consultations. Drawing on previous research, this study identifies Lundquist's dimensions of capacity, willingness, and understanding as an useful analytical framework for exploring how Swedish municipalities reason when deciding whether to participate in EU public consultations. The study is based on qualitative semi-structured respondent interviews with representatives from 14 Swedish municipalities. The result shows that Swedish municipalities approach participation as a question of whether consultations are perceived as meaningful, whether participation aligns with their understanding of their administrative role within the EU, and whether they have the organisational capacity to engage.

Keywords are: Sweden, municipalities, EU public consultations.

Table of Content

1. Introduction	4
2. Literature review	7
2.1 EU Public consultations	7
2.2 Subnational authorities and strategies of EU influence	9
2.3 Swedish municipalities in national and EU consultation systems	11
2.4 Research gap	12
3. Theory	13
3.1 Capacity	13
3.2 Willingness	14
3.3 Understanding	15
3.4 Research questions	16
4. Method	17
4.1 Selection	18
4.2 Participant Recruitment	21
4.3 Overview of Respondents and Their Experience with EU Consultations	21
4.4 Conduct of the Interviews	23
4.5 AI Declaration	24
4.6 Analytical framework	24
4.7 Limitations	25
5. Results	27
5.1 Understanding of the Municipal Role	28
5.1.1 Municipalities as Influencing Actors	28
5.1.2 Expectations of External Guidance	30
5.1.3 Summary of Understanding Dimension	30
5.2 Willingness: Perceived Meaningfulness of EU Consultations	31
5.2.1 The possibility to influence	31
5.2.1.1 Collective vs. Individual Influence	34
5.2.2 Perceived distance from the EU	35
5.2.3 Preparedness perspective	36
5.2.4 Summary of Willingness Dimension	37
5.3 Capacity	37
5.3.1 Time Constraints	38
5.3.2 Staff Competence	39
5.3.3 Financial Resource Constraints	41
5.3.4 Summary of Capacity Dimension	41
5.5 Summary of Main Findings	42

6. Discussion	43
7. Conclusion	44
8. Sources	48
9. Appendix	52
9.1 Interview guide in Swedish	52
9.2 Interview guide in English	54

1. Introduction

Swedish municipalities are highly affected by decisions made at the EU level, yet very few of them use the EU's public consultations to try to influence those decisions. A recent example is the highly debated EU Nature Restoration Regulation, which entered into force in 2024 (European Commission, 2024). In February 2026, the Swedish National Board of Housing, Building and Planning (Boverket) identified 22 municipalities in Sweden that must ensure that green areas do not decrease in order for Sweden to meet the regulation's targets. These requirements have been described as very difficult to fulfil (SVT, 2026). The EU Commission held a consultation, which formed part of the evidence base for the design of the Nature Restoration Regulation (Commission, 2021a, p.2). The consultation was launched in 2021 and received 111,838 responses. In Sweden, 3,567 responses were submitted. Only two Swedish municipalities participated in the consultation, none of the municipalities later identified as needing to preserve or increase green space were among the respondents (Commission, 2021b¹).

Given that EU public consultations are open and accessible to a wide range of stakeholders, including local authorities (Commission, 2002, p.5), the low level of engagement from Swedish municipalities is puzzling. The aim of this study is therefore to examine how Swedish municipalities reason about EU public consultations, specifically when deciding whether to respond to them or not.

While municipalities operate at the frontline of EU policy implementation (Danielsen & Trondal, 2025, p.1023), research on subnational EU lobbying has mainly focused on regions in federal states or large unitary states, while little is known about subnational EU lobbying in small unitary states, such as Sweden (Grønnestad, 2024, p.627). Furthermore, their horizontal engagement, such as participation in transnational municipal networks, has received considerably more attention than their vertical engagement (Danielsen & Trondal, 2025,

¹ The figures are based on the Excel file 'Contributions', available for download on the consultation webpage here: https://ec.europa.eu/info/law/better-regulation/have-your-say/initiatives/12596-Protecting-biodiversity-nature-restoration-targets-under-EU-biodiversity-strategy/public-consultation_en https://ec.europa.eu/info/law/better-regulation/have-your-say/initiatives/12596-Protecting-biodiversity-nature-restoration-targets-under-EU-biodiversity-strategy/public-consultation_en

p.1022). As EU public consultations allow actors to submit input directly to the European Commission (Van Hecke, Bursens & Beyers, 2016, p.1433), they represent a form of vertical engagement. While independent lobbying at the EU level remains highly costly (Lidström, 2020, p.143), EU public consultations may offer a comparatively less resource-intensive channel through which actors can seek to influence EU policymaking.

Despite this potential, previous research has identified several constraints on participation in EU public consultations, with particular emphasis on the importance of organisational resources (Quittkat, 2011, p.668; Nørbech, 2024, p.130; Røed & Hansen, 2018, p.1446). Research on subnational authorities further shows that they often prioritise intra-state channels of influence, as these are perceived as more effective (Bursens & De Blauwer, 2018, p.601; Grønnestad, 2024, p.626), which suggests that participation in EU public consultations is also shaped by actors' perceptions of the effectiveness of different channels. Moreover, research on Swedish municipalities shows that they remain primarily oriented toward the downstream implementation of EU rules rather than upstream policy-making influence (Danielsen et al., 2025, p. 6), suggesting that influencing EU policymaking may be perceived as outside the municipalities' administrative role. However, how municipalities themselves reason about their participation in EU public consultations remains largely unexplored.

Drawing on previous research, this study identifies Lundquist's dimensions of capacity, willingness, and understanding as an useful analytical framework for exploring how Swedish municipalities reason about participation in EU public consultations, an aspect that remains underexplored in the existing literature.

Sweden constitutes an interesting case due to municipalities strong local autonomy and extensive responsibilities, with formal opportunities to engage in EU processes (Lidström, 2020, pp.138,141), while also being directly or indirectly affected by a substantial share of EU policies and legislation (SKR, 2025, p.6). Yet, it seems that Swedish municipalities remain primarily oriented toward the downstream handling and implementation of EU rules rather than upstream policy-making influence (Danielsen et al., 2025, p.6). This is somewhat surprising, given the extent to which municipalities are affected by EU legislation, as

illustrated by the Nature Restoration Regulation introduced earlier. It may also be seen as problematic, since municipalities are expected to represent local populations and act in their interest. The overarching research question is thus: *How do Swedish municipalities reason about whether to participate or not participate in EU public consultations?*

By focusing on internal considerations within municipal administrations, the study contributes to research on subnational EU lobbying by providing evidence from a small, decentralised unitary state context that has received limited attention in existing research. The study is also relevant from a democratic perspective, as an understanding of how Swedish municipalities reason about participation in EU public consultations is important for assessing the inclusiveness and legitimacy of EU decision-making processes, particularly given the role of local authorities in implementing EU policies.

This is examined through respondent interviews with representatives from 14 Swedish municipalities, and the findings indicate that they approach participation as a question of whether consultations are perceived as meaningful, whether participation aligns with their understanding of their administrative role within the EU, and whether they have the organisational capacity to engage. As meaningfulness, understanding, and capacity are shown to be important for participation in EU public consultations, this study also makes a theoretical contribution by demonstrating that Lundquist's framework for successful policy implementation can be applied to the analysis of policy formulation.

The next section presents the literature review, followed by the theoretical framework and sub-research questions, the methodology, the results, the discussion, and finally the conclusion. This structure guides the study from existing research and theory through to empirical analysis and overall findings.

2. Literature review

The aim of this literature review is to outline existing research on the factors that shape the participation of Swedish municipalities in EU public consultations, in order to develop a

clearer understanding of the motivations and constraints influencing their participation. The research forming the basis of this thesis can be divided into three main strands. First, there is research on EU public consultations in general, with a particular emphasis on participation bias. While this body of research examines patterns of participation in consultations, it provides only a limited understanding of why certain actors choose not to participate. Consequently, it has been necessary to complement this literature with research on subnational authorities as EU actors, focusing on the channels through which they pursue lobbying activities. However, this body of research has also provided limited insight into how these actors themselves reason about participation. Finally, given the limited research on Swedish municipalities and EU public consultations, this thesis draws on studies of how Swedish municipalities perceive their role within the EU and how they engage with a comparable process, namely the national referral (remiss) system.

2.1 EU Public consultations

The European Commission introduced online consultations in the early 2000s as a tool for collecting input from a wider public and for improving the democratic quality of its decision-making processes (Quittkat, 2011, p.654). The Commission conducts, on average, more than 100 public consultations per year (European Court of Auditors, 2019, p.4). All the consultations are posted on the commission's 'Have Your Say' website portal, where you can view upcoming initiatives, each chance to give feedback during an initiative and translate information into all EU languages (European Court of Auditors, 2019, p.8). Consultations are mandatory for initiatives with impact assessments, evaluations, consultative communications and green papers (European Court of Auditors, 2019, p.11). It is therefore the responsibility of anyone wishing to be involved to stay updated on upcoming consultations via their website.

Although the Commission has established a long-standing system of public consultations, it remains somewhat unclear how responses are evaluated and how this input is processed and translated into policy outcomes. Quittkat (2011, p.663) highlights that it is frequently unclear how submitted contributions are assessed in consultation reports and how they influence final proposals, as evaluation standards remain poorly defined and considerable discretion is

exercised by Commission officials. In contrast, Bunea, Wuest, and Lipcean (2025, p.779) demonstrate that consultation input is often structured along one or two main lines of disagreement, indicating that stakeholder preferences are systematic rather than chaotic. This lack of clarity regarding how consultation input is translated into policy outputs may therefore limit its perceived value as a channel for influencing policy outcomes.

Compared to similar procedures at other levels of government, EU public consultations place particular emphasis on involving external stakeholders, which has been interpreted as a response to persistent concerns about the EU's democratic legitimacy (Rasmussen & Carroll, 2014, p.449). A person or organisation can be considered a stakeholder, for example, if they may be affected by the initiative, have relevant knowledge, show an interest, or may help in its implementation (Commission, 2025, p.469). Stakeholder categories include, among others, citizens, businesses, research and academic institutions, national public authorities, regional and local authorities, interest organisations, and non-governmental organisations (Commission, 2025, p.468).

Despite the emphasis on involving a broad range of stakeholders, quantitative studies of participation patterns in public consultations show a clear participation bias, with contributions dominated by business and industry actors (Nørbech, 2024, p.131; Quittkat, 2011, p.669; Røed & Hansen, 2018, p.1449; Rasmussen & Carroll, 2014, p.457). One factor that can mitigate this bias is high salience, as consultations on highly salient topics increase the expected benefits of participation and thereby encourage broader involvement. Yet, even salient issues tend to attract limited participation when technical barriers remain high (Røed & Hansen, 2018, p.1457). Another factor is the design of the consultations, as more open consultation formats are associated with broader participation. However, as consultations become more standardised and technical, they tend to reinforce self-selection and favour actors with specialised knowledge, such as business and industry groups (Quittkat, 2011, p.661). Within the literature on participation patterns in EU public consultations, the participation of subnational authorities remains comparatively underexplored (Van Hecke, Bursens & Beyers, 2016, p.1434).

To summarize, EU public consultations were introduced to enhance the democratic legitimacy of EU decision-making by including a broad range of stakeholders (Rasmussen & Carroll, 2014, p.449). However, existing research shows that it remains somewhat unclear how responses are processed and evaluated (Quittkat, 2011, p.663), which may limit their perceived value as a channel for influencing policy outcomes. Furthermore, studies identify a clear participation bias and suggest that participation follows a cost-benefit logic (Quittkat, 2011, pp.668-669; Nørbech, 2024, pp.130-131; Røed & Hansen, 2018, pp.1446,1449). However, less is known about the participation patterns of subnational authorities (Van Hecke, Bursens & Beyers, 2016, p.1434) and, more generally, about how actors themselves reason about participation in these consultations. Examining how subnational authorities reason about participation may therefore provide a deeper understanding of the considerations shaping their participation decisions than quantitative studies alone can capture.

2.2 Subnational authorities and strategies of EU influence

This section will examine how subnational authorities act as EU actors, focusing more specifically on how they seek to influence EU policymaking. Grønnestad (2024, p.628) classifies the ways in which subnational authorities seek to exert influence within the EU's multilevel governance system as "intra-state" or "extra-state". Intra-state strategies involve attempting to shape national positions on EU issues, primarily by working through national governments or local government associations, as they often possess greater access to the national government. Extra-state means bypassing the national government and going straight to EU-level (Grønnestad, 2024, p.628). Answering EU public consultations can thus be understood as a form of extra-state lobbying that allows actors to submit input directly to the European Commission (Van Hecke, Bursens & Beyers, 2016, p.1433).

The literature points to a preference for intra-state strategies among regions in federal contexts, which appears to be linked to the institutional structure of EU decision-making. As the Commission primarily consults member states, and both the Council and the European Council are composed of national representatives, the system is fundamentally state-centred

(Bursens & De Blauwer, 2018, p.601). Influencing the national government and relying on intra-state channels is therefore often considered the most effective strategy (Bursens & De Blauwer, 2018, p.601). This is consistent with Van Hecke, Bursens and Beyers (2016, p.1445), who suggests that regions with greater authority tend to develop well-established intra-state strategies, which in turn may reduce their participation in EU public consultations.

The preference for intra-state strategies seem to be present in a Scandinavian context too, as Grønnestad (2024, p.635-637) found that representatives from Oslo and Stockholm state that they mainly engage in extra-state lobbying when their preferences diverge from national positions. Furthermore, Grønnestad (2024, p.628) notes that while southern European cities often rely on personal ties between local and national politicians to access national decision-making, Scandinavian municipalities typically exercise intra-state channels by operating through strong local government associations that represent cities and regions collectively.

Overall, this section shows that subnational actors in the EU choose their strategies of influence based on how they assess the effectiveness of different channels, where intra-state strategies are often perceived as the most effective (Bursens & De Blauwer, 2018, p.601). On the one hand, extra-state strategies are often understood as resource-intensive and therefore more accessible to well-resourced actors (Nørbech, 2024, p.131; Quittkat, 2011, p.669; Røed & Hansen, 2018, p.1449; Rasmussen & Carroll, 2014, p.457). On the other hand, subnational authorities with greater authority, who would be expected to possess such resources, still tend to rely on intra-state channels (Van Hecke, Bursens and Beyers, 2016, p.1445). This implies that participation in EU public consultations cannot primarily be understood as a matter of capacity, but rather as shaped by actors' own perceptions of the effectiveness of different channels.

2.3 Swedish municipalities in national and EU consultation systems

This section examines the role of Swedish municipalities in EU policymaking. Due to limited research on their engagement with EU public consultations, it also considers their role within the Swedish referral system as a point of reference.

Sweden is commonly characterised as a decentralised unitary state in which municipalities possess extensive resources, broad functional responsibilities, and a high degree of local self-government (Lidström, 2020, p.138). Compared to regions, Swedish municipalities control a wider range of policy areas and administrative resources and are responsible for core welfare functions such as education, social services, and land-use planning (Lidström, 2020, pp.140-141). As a result, municipalities are affected by EU legislation across a wide range of policy areas. Furthermore, their engagement in and lobbying within EU policymaking are generally regarded as legitimate within national legal boundaries, even though municipalities in unitary states such as Sweden are not permitted to pursue an independent foreign policy (Lidström, 2020, p.141).

Discussing the Swedish referral system is relevant here because it illustrates how Swedish municipalities function as consultation actors within a well-established national framework, providing an important point of reference for understanding their potential role in EU public consultations, where research remains limited. The Swedish referral system constitutes a central consultative mechanism in national policymaking, through which government proposals are circulated to relevant authorities and organisations for written comments (Petersson, 2015, p.653). The procedure of the Swedish referral system is regarded as transparent and trustworthy, as submitted responses are publicly documented and formally acknowledged in the legislative process (Eriksson, Lemne & Pålsson, 1999, p.20). Within this system, municipalities have an established role as consultation actors and display consistently high participation rates (Eriksson, Lemne and Pålsson, 1999, p.48).

While little is known about how Swedish municipalities use EU public consultations, Danielsen et al. (2025, p.6) show that they are primarily engaged in the downstream implementation of EU legislation rather than in influencing EU policy, having become part of a multi-level administration in which they act as agents responsible for carrying out shared legislation. While the seemingly high level of engagement in the national referral system and

low level of engagement in EU public consultations² may reflect that municipalities perceive national decision-making as more directly relevant to their responsibilities, this interpretation is somewhat difficult to sustain, given that approximately half of the agenda items discussed in Swedish municipal councils are estimated to be directly or indirectly affected by EU policies and legislation (SKR, 2025, p.6).

Overall, this section shows that Swedish municipalities are strongly established and institutionalised consultation actors within the national consultation system, where they actively participate (Eriksson, Lemne and Pålsson, 1999, p.48). At the same time, their engagement in EU-related policymaking is both legitimate within national legal frameworks and relevant to municipalities themselves, as their extensive welfare and administrative responsibilities (Lidström, 2020, pp.140-141) suggests that they are significantly affected by EU legislation. Despite this, their role within the EU appears to be more closely associated with implementation than with attempts to influence policy formulation (Danielsen et al., 2025, p.6). This may be explained by how they understand their role within the EU, particularly whether they perceive themselves primarily as implementers or as influencers of EU policy.

2.4 Research gap

Taken together, the research points to three types of factors that may shape how municipalities reason about participation in consultations and the decision to respond or not: organisational resources, perceptions of the effectiveness of different channels of influence, and role conceptions within the EU. However, existing studies do not examine how municipalities themselves reason about these factors, nor whether they also take other considerations into account in relation to their engagement in EU public consultations. To address this gap, the study derives three guiding expectations based on Lundquist's (cited in Olsson et al., 2019) dimensions of willingness, understanding, and capacity.

² There are no official statistics providing a comprehensive overview of all public consultations and their respondents. The identification of what appears to be low engagement among Swedish municipalities is therefore based on a manual review of respondents listed in closed consultations on the European Commission's "Have Your Say" platform: https://ec.europa.eu/info/law/better-regulation/have-your-say/initiatives_sv.

3. Theory

Although originally intended as a framework for analysing implementation, this study uses Lundquist's dimensions as an analytical framework to explore policy formulation. Lundquist's dimensions: capacity, willingness, and understanding refer to having the capacity necessary to implement the policy, the willingness required for successful implementation, and an understanding of the policy to be implemented (Olsson et al., 2019, p.148). As successful implementation depends on the combined presence of all three dimensions, this suggests that the dimensions are interdependent. Lundquist highlights all three dimensions as necessary for successful policy implementation (Olsson et al., 2019, p.148). The factors identified in the literature as possibly shaping municipal participation in EU public consultations closely resemble Lundquist's three dimensions. However, it remains unclear whether these factors shape municipalities' reasoning about their engagement.

3.1 Capacity

Lundquist's dimension of capacity highlights that implementing actors need sufficient resources to implement policies, such as time, staff competence, reasonable budget allocations in relation to the task at hand (Olsson et al., 2019, pp.154,157). How public administrations are organized shapes the possibilities for realizing certain values in the implementation process and its consequences (Olsson et al., 2019, p.155). The amount of resources is an important limitation that may widen the gap between what bureaucrats would like to do and what they are actually able to achieve. This, in turn, may lead bureaucrats to lower their expectations of themselves and of the possibilities to deal with societal challenges (Olsson et al., 2019, p.156). A lack of capacity can also express itself by prioritising simple, routine matters at the expense of more complex and time-consuming cases, where no standardisation can be applied (Olsson, 2019, p.157).

When applying Lundquist's dimension of capacity to also include actors trying to influence rather than implement policy, participation in consultation procedures can similarly be understood as dependent on the resources available to the actor. Lobbying activities can be understood as resource-intensive, and low participation among municipalities is described by

Danielsen et al (2025, p.6) as more likely reflecting capacity limitations rather than formal restrictions.

One factor that complicates the relationship between the dimensions of capacity and understanding is that Lundquist argues that the practical experience of bureaucrats shapes their understanding (Olsson et al., 2019, p.151), while also identifying staff competence as a component of their capacity (Olsson et al., 2019, p.154). At the same time, practical experience can be understood as an integral part of staff competence. In this study, practical experience is treated as a question of capacity, as it is closely linked to competence and can be seen as a resource enabling participation.

3.2 Willingness

Participation in democratic processes is strongly shaped by people's perceptions of their ability to influence policy outcomes, with higher perceived efficacy leading to greater engagement in formal participatory arenas (Prats and Meunier, 2021, p.2). In this sense, perceived political efficacy is similar to Lundquist's concept of willingness, as both are rooted in actors' judgments about effectiveness.

According to Lundquist, willingness can be understood as the motivation needed to do a good job, and is central to successful implementation (Olsson et al., 2019, p.158). Motivation may relate to actors' judgments about the effectiveness and meaningfulness of different steering instruments and methods, as well as their own views on what works best, based on personal morals and knowledge rather than formal rules, education, and routines (Olsson et al., 2019, p.158).

The same dimension of willingness may also be relevant for actors who attempt to influence policy. Applied to the context of EU public consultations, participation in such procedures may be understood as dependent on actors' judgments of their effectiveness, more specifically, whether their input is perceived as meaningful and capable of influencing policy outcomes.

The preference for intra-state strategies among subnational authorities identified in the literature, even among those with greater authority (Grønnestad, 2024, pp.635–637; Van Hecke, Bursens & Beyers, 2016, p.1445), further suggests that participation in EU public consultations is shaped by whether such engagement is perceived as a meaningful and effective means of achieving influence compared to alternative strategies.

Since participation in democratic processes is shaped by perceptions of political influence (Prats and Meunier, 2021, p.2), and the structure of EU decision-making has been described as state-centered (Bursens and De Blauwer, 2018, p.601), a perception of the EU as detached from local realities may be closely linked to political efficacy. Greater perceived distance from the EU may reduce actors' belief in their ability to exert influence, and thereby lower their willingness to engage. Perceptions of the EU as distant are therefore treated as part of the willingness dimension, as they can be expected to shape actors' judgments about the effectiveness and meaningfulness of participation.

3.3 Understanding

Lundquist's dimension of understanding means that implementation is dependent on how a policy is interpreted and applied (Olsson et al., 2019, p.148). Employees in administrations and organizations may sometimes have difficulty understanding what decision-makers and managers expect from them (Olsson et al., 2019, p.148). Abstractly formulated goals, goal complexity, and contradictory steering from different channels mean that implementing actors may find it difficult to understand the meaning of the policy (Olsson et al., 2019, p.149). Within the dimension of understanding, there is a horizontal challenge in getting different administrations and professions to cooperate to achieve a common handling of complex cases (Olsson et al., 2019, p.149). The vertical challenge has to do with different interpretations between different levels of administration, and is particularly present in the multilevel governance of the EU, where policy goals are communicated from level to level, and risks getting more unclear along the way (Olsson et al., 2019 p.149-150).

When applying the dimension of understanding to actors who attempt to influence policy, the vertical communication challenge becomes particularly relevant in relation to participation in

EU public consultations. This challenge highlights how bureaucrats at different administrative units and levels often have an institutionalized way of handling implementation, relying on their professional knowledge and practical experience when deciding how a policy should be interpreted and implemented. The social interactions and experiences that shape how policies are interpreted and applied are largely generated within each specific organization and department, while communication between levels is more limited (Olsson et al., 2019, p.151).

Previous research further suggests that Swedish municipalities are primarily involved in the implementation and handling of EU legislation and that upstream policy-shaping activities, such as participation in EU public consultations, do not constitute a central part of their core administrative tasks (Danielsen & Trondal, 2025, p.1023; Danielsen et al., 2025, p.4). Lower municipal participation in EU public consultations may therefore reflect uncertainty about whether such engagement goes against their institutionalized way of working with EU policy as primarily implementers instead of as influencers. In other words, participation may depend on how municipalities understand their role as actors within the EU.

3.4 Research questions

By applying Lunqvist's framework, the study addresses the gap regarding how internal considerations shape Swedish municipalities' decisions to engage in EU public consultations. The overarching research question of this study is: *How do Swedish municipalities reason about whether to participate or not participate in the Commission's public consultations?* Based on this overarching question, three sub-questions are formulated, each corresponding to one of Lundquist's dimensions.

Lundquist's dimension of willingness is in this study defined as municipal actors' perceived motivation to engage in EU public consultations, particularly whether they regard consultations as a meaningful channel for influence. The first sub-question is therefore: *How do municipalities reason about the meaningfulness of EU public consultations when deciding whether to participate in them?*

Lundquist's dimension of understanding is in this study defined as municipal actors' interpretations of their administrative role within the EU, including whether participation in EU public consultations is perceived as part of their responsibilities. The second sub-question is thus: *How do municipalities reason about their understanding of their administrative role within the EU when deciding whether to participate in EU public consultations?*

Lundquist's dimension of capacity is in this study defined as municipal actors' perceived ability to engage in EU public consultations, based on their assessment of available organisational resources. The last sub-question is thus: *How do municipalities reason about their perceived organisational resources when deciding whether to participate in EU public consultations?*

4. Method

The aim of this study is to examine how Swedish municipalities perceive and reason about participation in EU public consultations, specifically how they decide whether to respond or not. Rather than gathering factual accounts of formal routines or measuring participation rates, the study seeks to understand the perception of consultations that shapes these decisions. Respondent interviews are useful when the aim is to capture individuals' perceptions of different issues, as such perceptions cannot be understood as true or false (Esaiaasson et al., 2017, p.268).

The choice to conduct respondent interviews is motivated by the fact that it is not possible to obtain an objective or externally verifiable answer to how municipalities perceive the meaningfulness of EU public consultations or how they understand their own role within the EU, as such perceptions are inherently subjective. When it comes to Swedish municipalities' capacity to respond to EU public consultations, certain indicators may be quantified. For example, Berg (1999, p.11) examined whether municipalities had staff assigned to EU-related matters or were affiliated with a regional office in Brussels in order to determine whether they could be classified as "EU-municipalities." However, such structural indicators do not fully capture how capacity is perceived, prioritised, and translated into action within

municipal administrations. To quote Magnusson and Marecek (2015, p.2): “People’s own words afford the best access a researcher can have to how they understand their experiences.”

4.1 Selection

This sampling strategy aims to maximise variation across factors that may influence municipal participation in EU public consultations. Since EU lobbying was initially concentrated among larger Swedish municipalities with greater administrative and financial resources (Lidström, 2020, p.143), there is reason to believe that the size of the municipality may still influence patterns of participation. Accordingly, the sample was designed to include an equal number of larger and smaller municipalities, although this balance was not fully achieved. In addition, the smaller municipalities in this study were classified as rural, given that the EU differentiates between urban and rural areas across several policy domains and funding instruments³ (Commission, 2026), which may influence how municipalities reason about participation in EU public consultations.

Geographical variation was included to account for potential contextual differences between regions that may influence how municipalities reason about participation in EU consultations. The aim was to include one larger and one smaller municipality⁴ from each of Sweden’s eight NUTS2 regions. NUTS (Nomenclature of Territorial Units for Statistics) is the EU’s regional classification system (SCB, 2025). However, this was not possible due to a lack of responses from municipalities. Despite this, at least one municipality from each NUTS2 region is represented in the sample. It is not possible to disclose which municipalities from specific regions have responded, as participants were guaranteed anonymity and such disclosure could enable their identification.

Van Hecke, Bursens and Beyers (2016, p.1445) demonstrate that participation by subnational authorities in EU policymaking is more likely when strong private or organised regional

³ For example, the EU’s Cohesion Policy differentiates between types of territories, such as urban areas, border regions, and remote or sparsely populated areas, through targeted investment instruments (European Commission, 2026).

⁴ All population statistics are obtained from SCB, *Population statistics - Population size and population changes (quarterly data, Quarter 4, 2025)*, available at: <https://www.scb.se/hitta-statistik/statistik-efter-amne/befolkning-och-levnadsforhallanden/befolkningens-sammansattning-och-utveckling/befolkningsstatistik/pong/tabell-och-diagram/folkmand-och-befolkningsforandringar---manad-kvartal-och-halvar/folkmand-och-befolkningsforandringar---kvartal-4-2025/>

interests are present. However, they note that it is unclear whether private interests encourage sub-national authorities to participate, or whether sub-national authorities mobilise first and attract private actors (Van Hecke, Bursens & Beyers, 2016, p.1446). Since indicators such as “best business climate” primarily capture perceptions of administrative conditions for entrepreneurship rather than the structural presence of dominant private economic actors (Svenskt Näringsliv, 2025), this study relies on the Swedish Agency for Economic and Regional Growth’s (Tillväxtverket) classification of municipalities with high dependence on a limited number of private-sector employers (Tillväxtverket, 2022). This category more closely captures the structural presence of concentrated private economic interests that, theoretically, may incentivise EU engagement.

A stepwise selection procedure was applied across all categories. Within each NUTS2 region, the largest municipality was contacted first. In cases of non-response, progressively smaller municipalities were approached until a municipality agreed to participate. This procedure was applied both to the larger municipalities and to those within the “rural” category and the group characterised by a high dependence on private actors. Given this approach, the sample captures a large share of the Swedish municipalities that typically respond to public consultations, as very few of them participate⁵. As such, it allows for cautious conclusions about how Swedish municipalities that regularly engage in consultation processes tend to reason and approach these issues.

The initial sampling strategy aimed to include the largest municipalities within the “rural” category, as well as those identified as highly dependent on private actors, in order to reduce the likelihood that variation in responses could be explained solely by differences in administrative capacity. However, due to limited availability and low response rates among these municipalities, the final sample consisted of mainly smaller municipalities within these categories, with populations ranging from approximately 4,000 to 17,000 inhabitants. All

⁵There are no official statistics providing a comprehensive overview of all public consultations and their respondents. The identification of Swedish municipalities that regularly participate in consultations is therefore based on a manual review of respondents listed in closed consultations on the European Commission’s “Have Your Say” platform: https://ec.europa.eu/info/law/better-regulation/have-your-say/initiatives_sv. This review suggests that participation is often dominated by larger municipalities. However, it should be understood as indicative rather than exhaustive, and may not capture all participating municipalities, which limits the scope for generalisation.

municipalities classified as rural, as well as those characterised by a high dependence on private actors, were invited to participate in the study, of which six ultimately did so.

In total, the sample includes eight municipalities classified as large, four classified as rural, and two classified as small. The classification follows the municipal grouping from 2023 by SKR. Larger municipalities refers to municipalities with more than 50,000 inhabitants, of which at least 40,000 reside in the municipality's largest urban area (SKR, 2023, p.16). Although SKR also defines an upper population threshold, this criteria has not been applied in this study in order to preserve respondent anonymity and avoid the identification of potential metropolitan municipalities. Small municipalities are defined as those with at least 15,000 and fewer than 40,000 inhabitants in the municipality's largest urban area (SKR, 2023, p.7). Rural municipalities are defined as those with fewer than 15,000 inhabitants in the municipality's largest urban area, combined with low commuting patterns (SKR, 2023, p.7). Furthermore, the two smaller municipalities and one of the rural municipalities are identified by Tillväxtverket (2022) as highly dependent on a limited number of private-sector employers, and one rural municipality with the same dependency.

One municipality had prior professional contact with the author. This is not considered to have influenced the analysis, and the municipality was included due to its relevance to the study.

4.2 Participant Recruitment

All municipalities were contacted through the general contact email listed on their official websites, which typically directs inquiries to a contact centre or registrar. The invitation included a description of the purpose of the study and allowed municipalities considerable discretion in selecting the most appropriate respondent. However, as the aim was also to include municipalities that do not respond to EU public consultations, it was suggested that, if no official was specifically responsible for such consultations, the interview could instead be conducted with officials working in strategic development or in policy areas significantly affected by EU policy, such as climate or sustainability.

Officials in strategic development were targeted because they are often involved in long-term planning, which is often influenced by EU policies and funding frameworks. Officials working with climate and sustainability were targeted since they work with policy areas that are strongly shaped by EU legislation and involve substantial municipal implementation responsibilities, an approach previously conducted by Danielsen and Trondal (2025, p.1027) in their study examining how bureaucrats perceive their roles between the EU and the municipal level. This suggestion was intended to reduce the likelihood of non-response due to a perceived lack of relevance. In the end, in addition to respondents whose roles explicitly included EU-related responsibilities, the sample included two municipal chief executives, one head of development, one process leader, and one environmental strategist. A control question concerned whether, and if so how, EU-related issues are part of their work. All respondents indicated that the EU is included in their work in some way, either through applying for funding, implementing legislation, or other related activities.

All respondents signed a consent form detailing the purpose of the study, how their data would be processed, and their rights as participants.

4.3 Overview of Respondents and Their Experience with EU Consultations

Roughly the same type of role can have very different titles, often very specific and possibly unique to a particular municipality. To avoid revealing which municipality they belong to, roles such as EU coordinator, EU and international strategist, and international and/or development strategist for EU affairs will all be grouped under the same title, which will be EU and International Affairs Professional. Municipalities are anonymised as follows: LM (large), SM (small) and RM (rural), followed by a number.

Municipality (Anonymized)	Respondent Position	Experience with EU Consultations
LM1a	Head of International and EU affairs	Responds to consultations
LM1b	EU and International Affairs Professional	Responds to consultations

LM2	EU and International Affairs Professional	Recently responded for the first time.
LM3	EU and International Affairs Professional	Responds to consultations
LM4	EU and International Affairs Professional	Possibly responded once, but uncertain
LM5	EU and International Affairs Professional	Possibly responded once via municipal company, but uncertain
LM6	EU and International Affairs Professional	Has not responded
LM7	EU and International Affairs Professional	Has not responded
LM8	Head of International and EU affairs	Responds to consultations
SM1 (high dependence on private actors)	Municipal chief executive	Has not responded
SM2 (high dependence on private actors)	Municipal chief executive	Has not responded
RM1	EU and International Affairs Professional	Possibly responded a few years ago, but uncertain.
RM2	Process Leader	Has not responded
RM3	Environmental strategist	Has not responded
RM4 (high dependence on private actors)	Head of development	Has not responded

4.4 Conduct of the Interviews

The interviews are structured around Lundquist's three dimensions of willingness, understanding, and capacity, which were introduced in the theory chapter. These dimensions are not treated as strict hypotheses but as thematic lenses guiding the interviews. Each

dimension is operationalised through open-ended questions. According to Magnusson and Marecek (2015, p.47), this format enables participants to respond in their own terms and to elaborate on experiences and interpretations beyond simple agreement or disagreement. Since not all of the selected municipalities have staff working solely with EU-related affairs, and the interview sample therefore also includes officials working in strategic development or in policy areas significantly affected by EU policy, such as climate or sustainability issues, the interview questions were not overly specific. To increase participation, the interviews were designed to take around 20 minutes, which was also stated in the invitations.

Furthermore, Magnusson and Marecek (2015, p.49) describe how semi-structured interviews should be conducted in a conversational tone, emphasising the importance of creating a relaxed setting in which participants feel comfortable sharing detailed accounts without fear of criticism. As recommended by Magnusson and Marecek (2015, p.56), the interview begins with simple warm-up questions intended to help the participant feel at ease. The questions then move from general background questions to more in-depth questions related to the three dimensions. This is described as important by Magnusson and Marecek (2015, p.56), since the easy questions give the participant confidence that they are able to take part in the interview, while easy questions also allow interaction to develop gradually. In line with the recommendations by Magnusson and Marecek (2015, p.57), the interview is then finished by giving the participants an opportunity to reflect on their answers and add anything further.

The interview guide can be found in the appendix. All interviews were conducted in Swedish, as this was more natural for the participants and allowed them to express themselves more freely in their primary work language.

4.5 AI Declaration

ChatGPT has been used throughout this study in order to improve the grammar. The prompt was: “keep as close to the original as possible but with correct grammar.” The audio recordings were transcribed using WhisperAI. Although direct translation from Swedish to English was possible, ChatGPT was used to assist in translating the interview quotes. These

translations were carefully reviewed and supervised to ensure that the original meaning was preserved and not distorted.

4.6 Analytical framework

The analysis was conducted using a qualitative thematic analysis. Following Braun and Clarke's (2022, p.4) definition, thematic analysis is used as a method for developing, analysing and interpreting patterns across a qualitative dataset, rather than a full methodology (Braun & Clarke, 2022, p.4).

The analytical process was carried out in several steps. First, all interview transcripts were read to gain an overall understanding of the material. In the second step, the material was coded manually by highlighting statements in the transcripts and assigning them different code labels (Braun and Clarke, 2022, p.65). The code labels captured specific meanings within the dataset that were relevant to the research question (Braun and Clarke, 2022, p.52), in this case, how municipalities reason about their decision to participate in EU public consultations.

In a subsequent step, the generated codes were examined in relation to Lundquist's three analytical dimensions: understanding, willingness, and capacity. These dimensions, together with expectations derived from previous research on EU consultations, subnational actors in the EU, and Swedish municipalities' participation in the national remiss system, served as an analytical framework for organizing and interpreting the codes. Each of Lundquist's dimensions was structured into a theme as they capture different aspects of the central concept within the dataset (Braun & Clarke, 2022, p.87).

Within the theme of willingness, the statements included reflect how meaningful respondents perceive consultations to be as a tool. Within the theme of understanding, the statements included reflect how respondents interpret their role within the EU, particularly in terms of whether they view themselves as influencers or implementers. Within the theme of capacity, the statements included reflect the availability of financial resources, competence, and time, and how these shape the ability to engage.

Several subthemes were identified within each theme, with each subtheme focusing on a specific aspect of its respective theme (Braun and Clarke, 2022, p.89). Within the theme of understanding, the subthemes are municipalities as influencing actors and expectations of external guidance. The willingness theme is divided into four subthemes: perceptions of the possibility to influence, the role of collective versus individual influence, perceived distance from the EU, and consultations as a tool for preparedness. Finally, the theme of capacity is divided into three subthemes: financial resources, time, and staff competence. An additional “other” category was initially included to capture codes that did not clearly fit within the three dimensions. However, this category was later deemed unnecessary, as all codes could be incorporated into the dimensions. While some overlap between the dimensions was identified, this is addressed in the discussion chapter.

4.7 Limitations

A total of 75 municipalities were invited to participate in this study, including all municipalities classified as “rural” and those identified as highly dependent on private actors. The intended sample consisted of 14 municipalities, evenly distributed across NUTS2 regions and size categories. However, this balance was not fully achieved. In addition, the study’s commitment to ensuring the anonymity of participating municipalities constrains the level of contextual detail that can be presented. This limits the possibility of explicitly distinguishing between specific municipal characteristics that may be analytically relevant, particularly where doing so risks breaching anonymity, for example in relation to characteristics such as population size or whether a municipality is metropolitan. However, this represents a necessary trade-off to encourage participation and ensure that respondents feel able to speak openly.

Furthermore, the time allocated to each interview was limited to approximately 20 minutes, with actual durations ranging from 10 to 30 minutes. The shorter interviews were mainly with those who had more limited familiarity with the topic of consultation and therefore less to elaborate on. This results in a risk that certain topics were not explored in equal depth across interviews. At the same time, respondents’ limited knowledge of consultations may itself be

understood as an empirical finding, reflecting variation in awareness or engagement with the issue across municipalities. With more time, the dataset could still have been supplemented by conducting additional interviews, particularly after it became clear that some interviews yielded limited material. The difficulty of recruiting participants made this unfeasible. Nevertheless, the material collected was sufficiently rich and comprehensive to support a meaningful analysis, as all three dimensions were explored in depth across all interviews.

The study is subject to potential selection bias, as participation is based on voluntary response. Municipalities that chose to participate may be those with a particular interest in EU affairs, greater awareness of consultation processes, or more positive attitudes toward participation. Thus, there is a risk that municipalities that are more critical of consultations, and their ways of reasoning, are not fully captured. However, the material also includes municipalities expressing more critical perspectives, suggesting that such views are at least partly captured.

One of the municipalities was known to the author through prior professional contact. This introduces a potential risk of response or interpretation bias. However, the municipality was included due to its relevance to the study, and the findings are interpreted cautiously as part of a broader analytical pattern.

5. Results

This chapter presents the empirical findings of the study and examines how Swedish municipalities reason about whether to participate in EU public consultations. The analysis is organised according to the three dimensions derived from Lundquist's framework: understanding, willingness, and capacity (cited in Olsson et al., 2019). The first section of the results begins with the theme of understanding, which is divided into two subthemes: municipalities as influencing actors and expectations of external guidance. It then turns to the theme of willingness, which is divided into four subthemes: perceptions of the possibility to influence, the role of collective versus individual influence, perceived distance from the EU,

and consultations as a tool for preparedness. Finally, the theme of capacity is presented, which is divided into three subthemes: financial resources, time, and staff competence.

Overall, the findings indicate that municipalities' reasoning about participation in EU public consultations is shaped by how they understand their role within the EU, their perceptions of the meaningfulness of consultations, and their available resources.

5.1 Understanding of the Municipal Role

This section examines how municipalities reason about participation in EU public consultations in relation to how they understand their role within the EU, namely whether they perceive their role as primarily situated in downstream implementation or upstream policymaking. According to Lundquist, the dimension of understanding refers to how well actors comprehend the tasks, goals, and expectations associated with administrative action (Olsson et al., 2019, p.148). Previous research further suggests that Swedish municipalities tend to perceive their role as primarily situated in downstream implementation rather than upstream policymaking (Danielsen & Trondal, 2025, p.1023; Danielsen et al., 2025, pp.4, 6). Based on this, the guiding expectation was that Swedish municipalities' reasoning about participation in EU public consultations reflects how they understand their role within the EU, whether primarily as influencers or implementers.

The results shows that an understanding of municipalities' role as influencing actors in the EU policy process is supported either by formal structures and policy frameworks or by normative considerations, such as democratic responsibility and proximity to citizens. Another way municipalities reason about EU policymaking is characterized by little or no direct engagement in lobbying activities, combined with an attribution of responsibility for municipal lobbying to SKR and the national government. This suggests that influencing EU policy is perceived as lying outside the municipality's administrative role.

5.1.1 Municipalities as Influencing Actors

Municipalities' understanding of their role as influencers appears to be grounded in a normative sense of responsibility toward their citizens, expectations from EU organisations to contribute to policymaking processes, and internal documents or organisational expectations.

The understanding of their role as influencing actors derived from internal expectations expressed in policy documents is reflected in the accounts of LM3 stating that: *"We follow the consultation processes. Our starting point is our international strategy or policy."* This indicates that lobbying is explicitly embedded in internal policy frameworks.

This is further illustrated by LM1a noting that: *"We have governing documents on this issue, including an EU policy that clearly sets out expectations."* Similarly, LM5 states that *"it is not specifically about EU consultations in our governing document, but rather more generally about advocacy work."*

Another view is that their role as influencing actors is based on a normative understanding of engagement in policy processes, rooted in democratic responsibility rather than formal organisational structures, as illustrated in LM2's statement: *"There is no EU policy without people, and we are the institution closest to them."* A similar understanding is expressed by LM3 and LM8, with LM3 describing themselves as *"the level closest to the citizens in this case"* and LM8 stating that *"you do your duty in a way. You have the chance to express your opinion, and then you need to do it. Otherwise, it's hard to complain afterwards if things turn out wrong."*

An understanding of their role as influencing actors is also evident in municipalities' expressed preference for strategies other than public consultations. There is a preference for working through organisations that represent them instead, which is reflected in LM4's statement that they prefer to pursue influence through networks and platforms, where municipalities can *"have a stronger voice"* and in RM4, as they prefer to work through organisations that *"may have a different perspective than metropolitan areas."* A similar

approach is evident in LM5, where engagement takes place through *“the organisations that represent us and put forward our views or other channels”*.

Another point of view is an underscoring of the importance of local politicians and engagement in Brussels as alternative forms of participation, which still point to an understanding of their role as influencing actors. RM1, for example, emphasises the role of active politicians, noting that they *“have local politicians who are also very engaged at the regional level in EU matters, and who also serve as representatives towards Brussels.”* LM6 highlights the importance of face-to-face contact, stating that *“You meet people in person...I think that makes more of a difference”*. LM6 further contrasts this with consultations, describing them as *“just ticking a bunch of boxes”*. Similarly, LM7 points to the value of physical presence in Brussels, noting that: *“It’s still the case that you kind of refresh or highlight for all politicians the opportunity to be able to influence things once you’re down in Brussels.”*

Another way of reasoning among municipalities is that influence is not considered part of the municipalities’ administrative role, as they do not engage in any form of lobbying towards the EU. This is illustrated by RM3 as they explicitly emphasise a focus on implementation rather than influence when describing how EU-related matters are part of their work, stating that *“once the legislation is in place, we need to consider what it means for us.”*

5.1.2 Expectations of External Guidance

Municipalities also expressed the view that greater responsibility should lie with the Swedish Parliament and SKR to actively promote participation in EU public consultations. This includes raising awareness, clarifying the importance of responding, and coordinating efforts to encourage municipal engagement.

For example, RM2 emphasises the need for stronger national coordination to increase municipal responses to EU public consultations, suggesting that *“maybe a clearer strategy is needed from the national level”* and that SKR *“maybe should have a clearer role there”*. A similar view is expressed by LM6 as they, when discussing how to increase municipal

responses, stated that *“maybe it needs to come from an organization, or SKR...maybe they could be even tougher on us as a municipality.”* This expectation is further reflected in SM2 suggesting that:

It probably would have been easier if there had been a clearer direction from the Swedish Parliament that these consultations exist...maybe a call to us municipalities that this is something you need to participate in or monitor, or whatever it may be...In reality, it is only the government, parliament, the state, and SKR that can coordinate all of them at the same time.

The perception that encouragement or instructions from the national government or SKR are necessary for municipalities to engage suggests a degree of uncertainty as to whether lobbying at the EU level is part of their administrative role.

5.1.3 Summary of Understanding Dimension

The empirical findings show that municipalities engage in some form of influence towards EU policy, even if they show a preference for strategies other than consultations. This engagement indicates that they understand their role as influencing actors in EU policy. At the same time, it is not possible to conclude that a lack of engagement in attempts to influence EU policy necessarily points to an understanding of their role as implementers. However, the view that greater responsibility should lie with SKR and the national government suggests that influencing EU policy is perceived as lying outside the municipality's administrative role.

5.2 Willingness: Perceived Meaningfulness of EU Consultations

This section examines how municipalities reason about participation in EU public consultations in relation to how meaningful they perceive their participation to be. The dimension of willingness refers to administrative action that is shaped by motivation and by actors' beliefs about what constitutes effective and appropriate action (Olsson et al., 2019, p.158). Taken together with research suggesting uncertainty regarding how consultation responses are processed (Quittkat, 2011, p.663), and that participation in democratic

processes is strongly shaped by actors' perceptions of their ability to influence policy outcomes (Prats and Meunier, 2021, p.2), the guiding expectation was that Swedish municipalities' reasoning about participation in EU public consultations reflects how meaningful they perceive these consultations to be as a tool for influence.

The findings suggest that low perceived impact on the ability to influence, due to a lack of tangible outcomes and a sense that individual voices are diluted at the EU level, reduces motivation to engage. A perception of the EU as detached from the local context further contributes to reduced willingness to participate. In addition, a preference for collective forms of influence, such as working through networks or with other actors, appears to further reduce the motivation to respond to EU public consultations.

5.2.1 The possibility to influence

The perceived meaningfulness of EU public consultations appears to be related to how high the expected impact is, as well as to the extent to which tangible outcomes are observed. In particular, municipalities report having received feedback from EU officials, which constitutes a tangible outcome that seems to contribute to perceptions of meaningful engagement. However, in the absence of such feedback, it becomes more difficult to assess whether participation has any real impact. This difficulty is illustrated by LM8, as they highlight how challenging it is to identify tangible outcomes when no feedback is received:

I don't know. It's hard to know, because you don't know what would have happened if you hadn't responded...We do make comparisons between what our municipality expressed in a consultation and what the outcome was. But it could have turned out that way anyway.

A similar uncertainty is expressed in LM3 noting that while feedback may be received in some areas where the municipality has authority, in other areas it feels like there is "*no one who cares*" whether they have responded, and the likelihood that their contributions are read is perceived to be low, as "*there aren't 20 officials in the Commission sitting and reading these responses.*"

The uncertainty regarding how the Commission assesses their responses is also reflected in LM4's statement, where they note that the idea that a private person's input weighs the same as when a municipality of their size responds reduce the meaningfulness of consultations as a tool for influence:

if I'm sitting at home one evening and think 'this is what the EU should do,' does that carry the same weight as when a large municipality submits a document that has been reviewed and anchored politically? So I think it's admirable that the process is so open. But at the same time, it feels a bit difficult to know whether what you do actually has an impact.

The importance of being able to trace tangible outcomes is also reflected in the accounts of LM1b, as they note that "*a consultation in itself does not have a significant impact*" but becomes meaningful "*when a dialogue emerges as a result of contributions made in a consultation*", for example when they "*have received a large number of follow-up questions and meeting requests from very senior officials within the EU institutions.*" However, in the absence of such feedback, participation may at times feel less meaningful, as "*at other times, it feels more like something you do simply because it is expected of you.*" LM1a further states that they "*believe that [responding to consultations] does have a certain level of impact*" while also noting that "*seeing our specific inputs reflected...is quite difficult.*"

The importance of tangible outcomes for EU public consultations to be perceived as meaningful is further highlighted by RM1 noting that their municipality previously "*had more of a focus solely on participating in EU consultations.*" However, this focus has since shifted, as they "*didn't really see the results of it.*" Instead, they emphasise that outcomes are easier to identify in other forms of EU engagement, such as project funding, as "*It's easier to see the results when we bring in project funding, you can actually measure that in money.*" On a similar note, LM6 states that they would need to see "*what kind of impact can this consultation have for our municipality*" for EU public consultations to be considered meaningful.

Another way of reasoning among municipalities suggests that the perceived meaningfulness of participation may be shaped more by expectations than by observable outcomes. This is evident in LM2, where the respondent states that they are *“very positive”* when asked about the meaningfulness of their participation, despite not having seen any tangible outcomes yet.

Furthermore, the perceived meaningfulness of EU public consultations appears to be related to the perception that municipalities’ voices carry limited weight at the EU level due to the large number of actors involved. This is illustrated by LM5, as they note that EU public consultations occur *“very early in the EU’s process”* and that the input received is therefore *“broad in nature”*. This suggests that they perceive the likelihood of their contributions having any impact to be low. A similar scepticism is expressed by RM3 asking whether the municipality is *“just one voice among how many millions?”*, while RM2 points to a perception of being *“too small a municipality”* for their contributions to produce results. Similarly, LM7 states that *“consultations probably come in from all over Europe anyway...That’s why I think it’s quite likely that there’s actually very little one can truly influence.”*

The perception of limited influence in EU public consultations is also expressed through a preference for national-level consultations. This is illustrated by RM4, as they note that they *“can have a slightly stronger voice”* in national consultations, since these *“clearly involve a somewhat more limited number of actors”*.

5.2.1.1 Collective vs. Individual Influence

Municipalities express that influence is primarily understood as a collective process, where impact depends on coordination with other actors rather than individual contributions. Thus, whether municipalities are able to act collectively appears to affect the perceived meaningfulness of EU public consultations. This is illustrated by LM1a, as they frame influence through consultations as a collective process, explaining that *“the goal is for as many actors as possible to provide the same input”* while emphasizing that change is driven by *“that collective voice”* rather than by a single municipality. LM1b expresses a similar

view, stating that *“the aim is for as many stakeholders as possible to provide their input. This allows for a more comprehensive understanding of the situation in practice.”*

This understanding of responding to EU public consultations as part of a broader collective action is further illustrated by LM2 and LM8. LM2 states that they have chosen *“to send our responses directly to the EU”* while also recognising the role of collective actors: *“we are very pleased that our issues are also raised through...an organization that represents our region’s interests in Brussels and within the EU.”* Similarly, LM8 notes that their responses to consultations can be used in *“cooperation with other cities”*.

Another perspective among municipalities suggests that prioritising collective action discourages participation in EU public consultations, with engagement instead taking place through other forms. This is illustrated by RM2 arguing that *“to have a real impact there [at the EU level], it is necessary to act as part of a larger group.”* Similar reasoning is expressed by LM4 questioning *“whether an individual municipality in Sweden carries more weight than an organization that represents many, so to speak”* and further notes that *“through those networks, we can have a stronger voice.”* RM4 likewise emphasises the need for collective action, explaining that *“it is, of course, difficult to believe that a single municipality in Sweden would have a major impact on its own; rather, you need to work together with others.”*

The preference for collective action is also expressed by a reliance on SKR, the regions and their regional offices for influence in EU policymaking. This is illustrated by LM4, as they note that: *“we largely rely on the organisations that represent us to also do so on behalf of Swedish municipalities, whether it is SKR or other types of city networks.”* RM2 further states that *“the region is responsible for quite a lot of these issues now”* while RM4 highlights *“good support from the region...and also from the Brussels office.”* In a similar manner, LM7 note that *“we receive a weekly newsletter from the Brussels office...where there are often various consultations”*, while SM1 state that in terms of lobbying, they have their *“regional representation in Brussels...working to bring back insights.”* This reliance may be

interpreted as a more passive form of engagement, where municipalities primarily receive information and support rather than actively influencing EU policy.

There is also an emphasis on the role of regions not only as intermediaries but also as broader coordination mechanisms. This is illustrated by LM4, as they argue that *“if the whole region says ‘this is how we want to do it,’ it is usually more effective.”* A similar view is expressed by RM1, as they motivate coordination with the region by noting that *“we are a small part of the EU, and we are also a small part of Sweden with specific conditions, and we have to come together.”*

Finally, another perspective of municipalities is that participation does not become meaningful unless it is grounded in the municipality’s own interests. For instance, LM3 draws a comparison to the business sector, stating that *“companies like Volvo do not work together with Fiat”* and argue that *“the same logic applies to municipalities.”* This indicates an understanding of the municipality as an individual influencing actor, where influence is primarily grounded in advancing its own interests rather than in collaborative engagement.

5.2.2 Perceived distance from the EU

Municipalities appear to perceive EU public consultations as less meaningful due to a sense that EU decision-making is distant and has limited relevance for their local context. This is illustrated by SM2, as they state that *“when, in the municipal context, one sees an EU consultation, one probably also tends to think that it is too far away”* and that they therefore *“probably don’t really understand the point of doing it [answering consultations]”*. SM2 further highlights a lack of clarity regarding their relevance, stating that: *“there would need to be a clearer link showing that what is decided at the EU level ultimately affects us as well.”* The view of the EU as too distant is also evident in RM1, where the respondent expresses a sense of marginality, stating that *“I think we have, or have had, somewhat of this perception that you disappear, that we are still quite peripheral.”*

A similar pattern is evident in LM6, as they note that it is difficult to get people within the municipality to understand how they are affected by EU legislation: *“everything is based on*

the decisions that the EU makes, which underpin all of our own decisions. Some of us probably understand how this all fits together, but it's very hard to get others on board."

A similar perception is also expressed by RM3, as they highlight both geographical and institutional distance, noting that *"In a relatively small municipality, far from the EU, both geographically and institutionally...it can feel like what we submit does not really matter...it simply does not feel meaningful."* The respondent also expresses uncertainty about whether such issues are recognised as something that may affect the municipality, stating that *"I don't know whether those consultations do not reach us, or whether it is simply that we are not very good at recognising that this could become an issue that affects us."*

5.2.3 Preparedness perspective

Although EU public consultations are sometimes perceived as less meaningful as a tool for influence, due to the difficulty of linking participation to tangible outcomes, they are nevertheless still seen as meaningful from a preparedness perspective.

This is illustrated by LM1a, as they state that participation in EU public consultations *"is also an aspect of how we, as a city, create preparedness and readiness for upcoming legislation."* Similarly, LM3 emphasises that consultations concern strategies, new legislation, or updates to existing legislation, noting that *"70-80 percent of the outcomes eventually affect municipalities in Sweden"* and that participation *"makes us better prepared, I think."* Finally, LM8 highlights that *"a consultation means that they are in the process of preparing legislation...In that way, you at least have early awareness of what is coming."* Taken together, these statements indicate that consultations are seen as meaningful in the sense that they provide early information on forthcoming legislative developments.

5.2.4 Summary of Willingness Dimension

The dimension of willingness is clearly present, as uncertainty about the influence of municipal input and the effectiveness of EU public consultations appears to reduce the willingness to respond. Interestingly, respondents who assess the impact of consultations as low are mainly those who have not participated in them, and their reasoning reflects a

perception of limited influence. In contrast, respondents who view consultations as meaningful are typically those who have engaged with them and, in some cases, received feedback from EU institutions. Although feedback is not always expected, consultations are still regarded as meaningful, particularly as they help municipalities prepare for upcoming legislation. This suggests that consultations are not primarily valued as a channel for influencing policy outcomes, but rather as a source of information and preparation, although it remains unclear whether this reflects limited confidence in their influence or a broader understanding of their function.

5.3 Capacity

This section examines how municipalities reason about participation in relation to perceived capacity. Lundquist's dimension of capacity refers to the extent to which actors possess the resources necessary to carry out administrative action. Such resources include financial resources, staff competence and time. Limited resources may lead actors to lower ambitions and prioritise simpler or more immediate tasks (Olsson et al., 2019, pp.154-157). Taken together with previous research showing that participation follows a cost-benefit logic (Quittkat, 2011, p.668; Nørbech, 2024, p.130; Røed & Hansen, 2018, p.1446), the guiding expectation was that Swedish municipalities' reasoning about participation in EU public consultations reflects their perceived capacity to engage. The results show that participation in EU public consultations is viewed as resource-intense and requires prioritisation. These constraints are particularly evident in relation to limited time, staff competence and financial resources.

5.3.1 Time Constraints

Municipalities express that time constraints are an important challenge in terms of capacity. Core responsibilities are described as taking up most of the available working time, leaving limited time to engage with EU consultations. This is illustrated by RM3, as they state that *"It is not the case that there are a lot of people sitting and twiddling their thumbs and have time to, like, just for fun respond to an EU consultation."* This is further highlighted by SM1, as they note that *"we don't have the time to be that strategic"*. Similarly, LM6 describes their

available time as “*quite limited*” while LM4 notes that “*our calendars are so incredibly full*”.

In addition to general time pressure, EU public consultations are described as requiring a more proactive approach compared to the Swedish remiss system. This is illustrated by RM3, as they state that EU public consultations require them to “*be more proactive and keep track of them yourself*”. This places additional demands on municipal staff in terms of time required to monitor and respond to relevant consultations.

Time constraints are also closely linked to prioritisation. This is illustrated by LM4, as they note that consultations are “*not the highest priority*” due to limited time available. The need for prioritisation is also expressed by LM7, as they state that a lack of general knowledge is not the main issue, but that even when expertise is available, limited time constraints the ability to engage:

I’m not sure that it would necessarily be needed to build up much more general knowledge...the question could instead be passed on to the relevant technical department...But unfortunately, I think that this type of work would likely be deprioritized, since what is often referred to as the municipality’s core responsibilities tends to take up most of the working time.

Time constraints are also reflected in the limited timeframes associated with certain consultations. LM1b emphasises the challenges this creates, particularly in relation to technically complex consultations:

when it comes to highly technical amendments to EU regulations and directives...the timeframes are much shorter...It is precisely at this level that changes are made. Within that timeframe, it is not only necessary to identify an expert who has both the capacity and time to review the proposal, but also to coordinate internally.

Taken together, these findings show that time constraints operate in several ways, including general workload pressures, the need for proactive engagement, and short response deadlines, all of which seem to limit the municipalities’ ability to participate in EU public consultations.

5.3.2 Staff Competence

There appears to be a lack of knowledge about how EU public consultations work in practice. Municipalities highlight uncertainty regarding internal procedures, such as who within the municipality should respond to consultations. This is illustrated by LM4, as they ask: *“Is it okay for me to respond...or should I raise it with my manager? Should it be taken to the political level?”*, by SM2, as they state: *“I actually have no idea. Who initiates a consultation, or how do you take part in one?”*, and by RM2 as they ask: *“Is it the European Commission that sends them out?”* and *“are they usually voluntary or mandatory?”*. LM6 also expresses uncertainty about how consultations reach municipalities, stating that *“I myself have never even been asked about this”* and asking: *“Who is the one being asked?”*

Municipalities also draw comparisons between EU public consultations and the Swedish referral system, highlighting a lack of competence regarding how EU consultations should be handled. This is illustrated by RM4, as they state that *“it’s [EU public consultations] essentially the same as when we provide input on national proposals”*, while still acknowledging a lack of knowledge regarding how to engage with EU public consultations: *“this experience and way of working...is clearly something we do not have.”* A similar comparison is made by LM4, as they describe the Swedish referral system as more familiar and embedded in existing administrative structures, noting that *“it’s not as clear as the Swedish referral process”* and explaining:

I heard someone in a role similar to mine [at another municipality] say that they had a system for responding to consultations...And that’s also how we handle [national] referrals today...we do not have a particular structure for EU consultations.

RM3 also makes this comparison, describing how national consultations are clearly integrated into administrative routines as *“they are sent directly to the municipality’s inbox and then assigned to a case officer”*. In contrast, the respondent expresses uncertainty about how to access EU public consultations: *“Maybe subscribe to the right newsletters, I don’t know.”* Furthermore, the respondent in RM2 suggested that *“if they [the Commission] want to*

get more feedback, I think it should be sent out more formally, like to the municipality's official registry inbox or something like that."

Taken together, these comparisons indicate that limited knowledge of how to integrate EU public consultations into everyday administrative work seems to limit their capacity to engage with them. Furthermore, it suggests that when engagement depends on individual initiative rather than established routines, consultations are more likely to fall through the cracks.

Constraints in staff competence are further reflected in limited technical and legal expertise among staff. For example, LM1b states that their competence *"largely depends on the nature of the issue in question"*, while LM3 similarly notes that their competence *"varies a bit."* This suggests that the ability to engage depends on access to specialised knowledge within the organisation. This is further illustrated by LM8:

You can't answer all types of questions. They can be a bit too legal or technical at times... For example, we have chosen not to respond to digital legislation... We think that even if it affects the city, we do not have the technical or legal expertise to fully understand that legislation before it is adopted.

The need for technical expertise is further reflected in the accounts of RM3 and SM2, as they express the need for a dedicated person within the municipality to work with these issues, but note that this is not possible due to limited resources. RM3 states that *"I actually think that there would be a need for a civil servant dedicated...to keep track of what we need to influence"*, while SM2 notes that *"we have limited capacity"* and that they *"don't have the scope to dedicate a specialized person"* showing how limited resources and the absence of dedicated expertise are perceived as barriers to engagement.

5.3.3 Financial Resource Constraints

In addition to time constraints and staff competence, financial resources are an issue that municipalities highlight when it comes to their capacity to engage with EU public consultations.

One way of reasoning about constraints in financial resources among municipalities is in more direct terms. This is illustrated by LM6, RM2, and RM4, where their financial resources are described as “*low*” and identified as the main barriers to engagement in EU public consultations. Similarly, LM2 describes consultations as “*very resource-intensive*” and notes that “*the issue of resources is the biggest challenge.*” Furthermore, SM1 states that “*we simply don’t have the capacity*”, while RM3 describes its financial resources as “*almost non-existent*”.

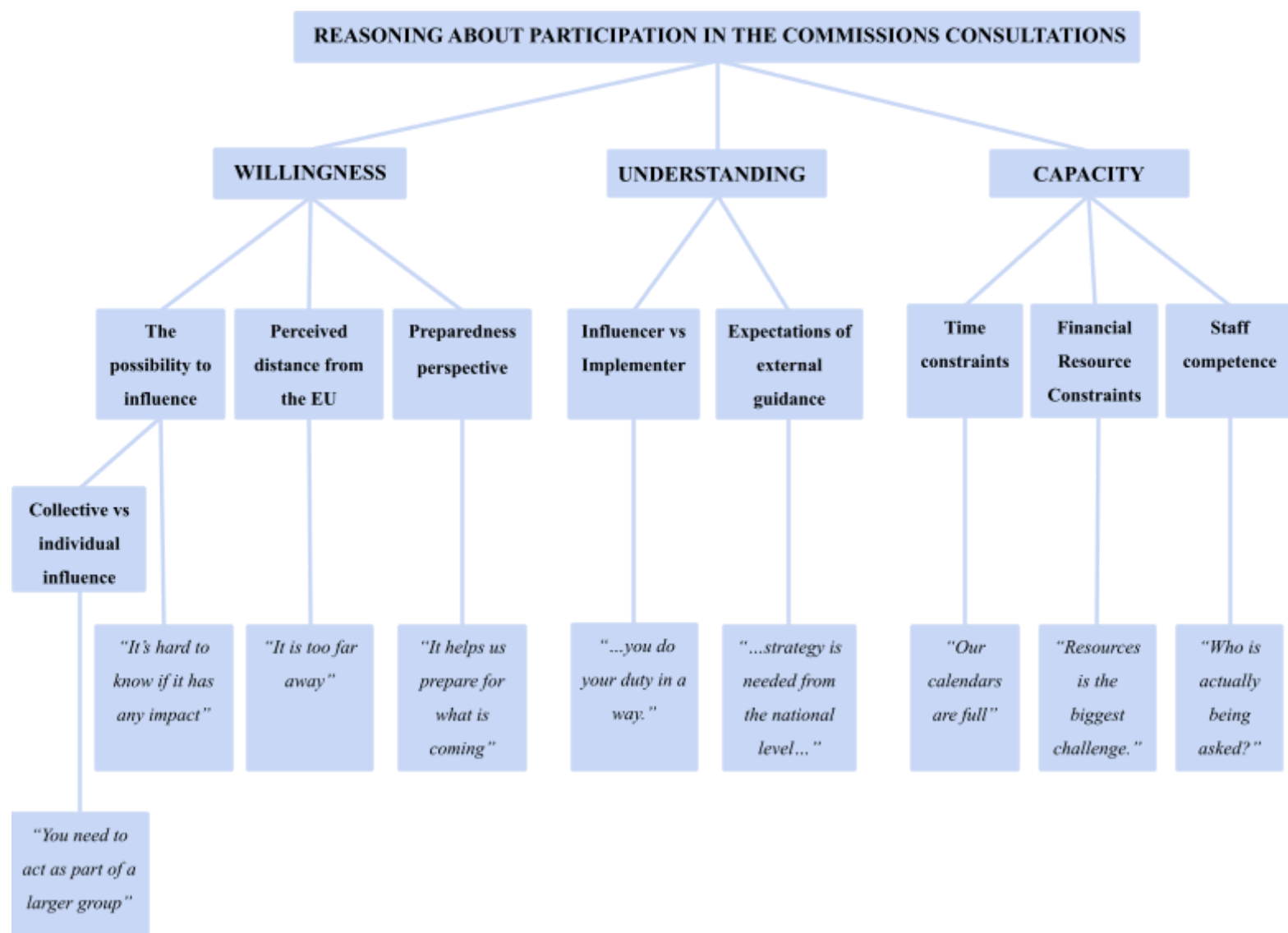
Another challenge relates to prioritisation within limited financial resources. This is illustrated by RM2, as they note that the prioritisation of financial resources becomes “*more of a matter of survival.*” This is further reflected in the accounts of LM5, as they explain that “*we are also somewhat deliberate in not allocating resources too early; instead, we prefer to contribute through organizations that represent us*”. However, LM5 still describes their financial resources to engage as high, if “*we assess that we really need to submit a written statement*”. While LM5 maintains that they possess the resources to participate, but deliberately choose to allocate them at a later stage, as this is considered more efficient, their approach can still be understood as reflecting a typical cost-benefit logic, shaped by resource constraints.

5.3.4 Summary of Capacity Dimension

The reasoning about capacity in the empirical material closely corresponds to Lundquist’s dimension of capacity, as time, staff competence and financial resources were identified as three subthemes. Resource constraints and the need to prioritise within limited time and financial resources were clearly present. From this perspective, EU-related engagement is not necessarily seen as irrelevant, but rather placed outside what is considered essential for fulfilling the municipality’s main responsibilities. This suggests that capacity constraints are not only about an absolute lack of resources, but also reflect ways of prioritising what is seen as legitimate and necessary administrative work.

5.5 Summary of Main Findings

The figure is organised with the overarching theme, reasoning about participation in EU public consultations, positioned at the top. Each analytical dimension is structured as a theme, which is further divided into subthemes illustrated through representative quotations from the respondents. “Collective vs individual influence” can be understood as a subtheme of the perceived possibility to influence, as it reflects the perceived meaningfulness of individual versus collective influence. The interconnections between these dimensions are examined in the discussion section below.



6. Discussion

This discussion will focus on the interconnectedness of the dimensions as reflected in the empirical material. While all dimensions are clearly present in the data, they also appear to be interrelated. For example, the preference for other forms of influence, particularly network-based engagement, appears across all dimensions. In the understanding dimension, this preference is evident insofar as it indicates that municipalities still perceive their administrative role as influencing EU policy, even though they do not primarily use EU public consultations for this purpose.

In the willingness dimension, networks are contrasted with and described as more meaningful than EU public consultations in terms of their perceived outcomes. This is in line with previous research on subnational authorities, which shows a preference for intra-state strategies (Grønnestad, 2024, pp.635-637; Van Hecke, Bursens & Beyers, 2016, p.1445), suggesting that participation in EU public consultations is shaped by whether such engagement is perceived as a meaningful and effective means of achieving influence compared to alternative strategies. This preference for networks is further reflected in the capacity dimension, where influencing EU policy through networks is described as a less resource-intensive means of exerting influence than participation in EU public consultations. This is consistent with previous research finding that participation follows a cost-benefit logic (Quittkat, 2011, p.668; Nørbech, 2024, p.130; Røed & Hansen, 2018, p.1446).

The perception of EU decision-making as too distant, as highlighted by the municipalities, further illustrates the interconnectedness between the willingness and understanding dimensions. This perception is categorised under the willingness dimension, since participation in democratic processes is strongly shaped by actors' perceptions of their ability to influence policy outcomes (Prats & Meunier, 2021, p.2), and the EU decision-making system has been described as state-centred (Bursens & De Blauwer, 2018, p.601). A perception of the EU as detached from local realities may therefore reduce actors' belief in their ability to exert influence, thereby lowering their willingness to engage.

At the same time, the perception of EU decision-making as distant also has implications for the dimension of understanding. Municipalities expressed that it was difficult to understand how they, as local authorities, are affected by decisions at the EU level. If municipalities do not understand how they are affected by EU legislation, it becomes more difficult to support the conclusion by Danielsen et al. (2025, p.6) that Swedish municipalities primarily understand their role as implementers of EU policy. Instead, it is possible that municipalities perceive their role primarily as implementers of national legislation, even when such legislation originates at the EU level but is transposed into Swedish law.

The preference for intra-state strategies were also present in both the understanding dimension and in the willingness dimension. However, a distinction can be made between the preference for intra-state strategies, discussed in the willingness dimension as being motivated by perceptions of their greater effectiveness, and the view that greater responsibility should be placed on SKR and the Swedish Parliament to ensure municipal participation, as discussed in the understanding dimension. The first is in line with previous research on Scandinavian municipalities, which shows that they typically rely on local government associations to represent them (Grønnestad, 2024, p.628). The latter points to a view of the EU primarily as an organisation of states, where the goal is for municipalities to contribute to a unified national position in the EU. It therefore also suggests an understanding of influencing EU policy as lying outside the municipality's administrative role, unless participation is requested by the national government or SKR.

7. Conclusion

The overarching research question of this study was: *How do Swedish municipalities reason about whether to participate or not participate in EU public consultations?* The findings show that Swedish municipalities approach participation in EU public consultations as a question of whether consultations are perceived as meaningful, whether participation aligns with their understanding of their administrative role within the EU, and whether they have the organisational capacity to engage.

According to Lundquist, willingness refers to the motivation needed for successful implementation and is shaped by actors' perceptions of the effectiveness and meaningfulness of different steering instruments (Olsson et al., 2019, p.158). Perceptions of meaningfulness are clearly evident in the empirical material, as low willingness to participate appears to be linked to uncertainty about whether municipal input has any real impact, a sense that individual municipal voices carry limited weight, and a perception that EU decision-making is distant from the local context. At the same time, municipalities that frequently participate tend to view EU public consultations as meaningful in a more instrumental sense, particularly as a way of preparing for upcoming legislation.

Lundquist defines the understanding dimension as how a policy is interpreted and applied, where an issue within this dimension is that employees in administrations and organisations sometimes have difficulty understanding what decision-makers and managers expect from them (Olsson et al., 2019, p.148). In this study, this dimension is used to examine whether engagement is expected of them or goes against their institutionalised way of working with EU policy as primarily implementers rather than influencers. In terms of how they understand their administrative role within the EU, municipalities appear to understand their role as influencers of EU policy, either through direct participation or via intermediary actors such as SKR, regions, networks, or Brussels offices. However, the view that greater responsibility should rest with the Swedish Parliament and SKR indicates an alternative perspective among municipalities, namely that influencing EU policy is not necessarily a task that individual municipalities are expected to pursue directly.

Lundquist's dimension of capacity highlights that implementing actors need sufficient resources to implement policies, such as time, staff competence, reasonable budget allocations in relation to the task at hand (Olsson et al., 2019, pp.154,157). The municipalities in this study also appear to reason about their perceived capacity in relation to time, financial resources, and staff competence when deciding whether to participate in EU public consultations. The empirical material shows that EU public consultations are often perceived as competing with core municipal responsibilities, being difficult to integrate into existing administrative routines, and being too technically demanding. This is in line with Lundquist,

who argues that a lack of capacity can manifest itself in the prioritisation of simple, routine matters at the expense of more complex and time-consuming cases (Olsson et al., 2019, p.57).

It seems that Lundquist's framework, originally intended for analysing successful policy implementation, provides a useful lens for understanding how Swedish municipalities reason about participation in EU public consultations. To the best of my knowledge, Lundquist's framework for successful implementation has not previously been applied to the analysis of policy formulation. This study therefore also makes a theoretical contribution by demonstrating that Lundquist's framework can be used to analyse policy formulation.

In this study, Lundquist's dimensions were not treated as strict hypotheses, but rather as analytical lenses guiding the analysis of how municipalities reason when deciding whether to participate in EU public consultations. While Lundquist emphasises that successful implementation requires the presence of all three dimensions (Olsson et al., 2019, p.148), this study has not assessed whether municipalities meet these conditions or whether such conditions are necessary for successful policy formulation. Such an assessment would require a clearer conceptualisation of what constitutes success in policy formulation and how participation in EU public consultations should be evaluated within such a framework.

If successful policy formulation is defined as responding to EU public consultations, as done by LM1a, LM1b, LM2, LM3 and LM8, then all three dimensions appear to be present in the cases analysed. The municipalities demonstrate an understanding of their role as potential influencers of EU policy. Furthermore, they perceive consultations as meaningful, although primarily in terms of improving preparedness for forthcoming legislation. At the same time, respondents express certain limitations in capacity. However, in cases where municipalities did respond to consultations, they nonetheless had sufficient capacity to provide input at those specific points in time.

As Swedish municipalities are known for possessing extensive resources, broad functional responsibilities, and a high degree of local self-government (Lidström, 2020, p.138), the fact that they nevertheless face difficulties engaging with such consultations raises concerns from

a democratic perspective. This suggests that municipalities in other countries, which may have more limited administrative capacity, are likely to face even greater barriers to participation. As such, the issue extends beyond the absence of a Swedish local perspective and points to a broader risk that local perspectives are systematically underrepresented in EU policymaking.

Given that the aim of EU public consultations is to be open and accessible to a wide range of stakeholders (Commission, 2002, p.5), it is notable that the technical demands of consultations risk undermining their inclusiveness in practice, and thereby their democratic function. One municipality highlighted a tension in that the most important changes are often found in highly technical details within consultations, where the timeframe to formulate a response is shorter, while another noted that they have at times refrained from participating in consultations of significant importance due to a lack of technical expertise. This is in line with previous research showing that more technically complex consultations primarily mobilise organised and resource-rich actors (Nørbech, 2024, p.130; Røed & Hansen, 2018, p.1457).

If the European Commission seeks to involve a broad range of stakeholders, it may need to address the barriers that currently privilege resource-rich actors with technical competence. The interviewed municipalities suggested several ways to facilitate participation, such as receiving formal consultation invitations through their official administrative channels. Some respondents also indicated limited awareness of these consultations and uncertainty regarding how the process functions. In this regard, the findings suggest that the Commission may benefit from more targeted communication strategies or awareness-raising measures to broaden participation beyond already well-connected actors.

Despite the evident need for further research on the participation patterns of subnational authorities in EU public consultations and the reasoning behind their decision whether to participate, future research should also examine how the consultation responses are translated into actual policy proposals. Previous research has highlighted a lack of clarity regarding how EU public consultation responses are treated (Quittkat, 2011, p.663), while the municipalities

in this study emphasised that such uncertainty reduces their willingness to engage with these consultations. Research on how input from EU public consultations is translated into policy proposals could either strengthen the perceived legitimacy of these consultations and encourage participation among actors who currently doubt their influence on policymaking processes, or show that non-participation has limited consequences, as consultation responses may have little impact on policy outcomes.

Given that the municipalities in this study perceive EU public consultations as meaningful in terms of preparing for forthcoming legislation, future research should also examine whether this represents a broader pattern. A relevant question is whether extensive participation in large-scale consultations, such as the consultation on the Nature Restoration Regulation mentioned in the introduction, mainly reflects actors' belief in their ability to influence policymaking or their need to anticipate and prepare for upcoming regulatory changes. If the latter is the case, the high number of responses, 111,838 in this instance, may be interpreted with caution, as such figures can be presented as evidence of trust in the consultation process, while they may instead reflect actors seeking to prepare for forthcoming policy developments or other underlying motivations.

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9. Appendix

9.1 Interview guide in Swedish

1. Introduktion och uppvärmning

- Tack för att du tagit dig tid att delta. Innan vi börjar, skulle du kort kunna beskriva din nuvarande roll i kommunen?
- På vilket sätt, om något, ingår EU-relaterade frågor i ditt arbete?

2. Huvudfrågor

- Har din kommun någon gång deltagit i ett EU-samråd?
- Följdfråga om ja: När var senaste gången ni deltog och hur kom det sig att ni deltog då?
- Följdfråga om nej: Hur kommer det sig?

2.1 Förståelse

- Upplever du att det finns några förväntningar på kommuner att delta i EU-samråd? (från eu-institutioner, nationella myndigheter/regering, intresseorganisationer eller nätverk, politiska förväntningar lokalt/den egna organisationen)
- Följdfråga om ja: skulle de kunna beskriva de förväntningarna?

- Följdfråga om nej: upplever du några andra förväntningar på hur kommuner ska agera i relation till EU:s beslutsfattande? (bidra med lokal kunskap, implementera EU-lagstiftning, representera lokala intressen, samarbete i europeiska nätverk etc).
- Upplever du att det är kommunens uppgift att svara på EU-samråd? (ser du det som en av kommunens givna arbetsuppgifter)

2.2 Vilja

- Hur ser ni på EU-samråd jämfört med andra påverkanskanaler, till exempel genom SKR eller medlemsorganisationer för kommuner såsom Eurocities?
- Hur bedömer du den potentiella effekten av att svara på EU-samråd?
- Följdfråga om de inte svarar på samråd: Under vilka omständigheter skulle deltagande i EU-samråd kännas meningsfullt eller värt att lägga tid på?
- Följdfråga om de svarar ibland/ofta: Vad är det som gör att deltagande i EU-samråd känns meningsfullt eller värt att lägga tid på?
- Hur prioriteras deltagande i EU-samråd inom organisationen?

2.3 Kapacitet

- Upplever du att det finns några faktorer som gör det lättare eller svårare för kommunen att delta i EU-samråd? Vilka då?
- Hur skulle du beskriva kommunens resurser när det gäller att arbeta med EU:s offentliga samråd?
- Hur skulle du beskriva kommunens kompetenser när det gäller att arbeta med EU:s offentliga samråd?

3. Avslutande reflektion

- Är det något du skulle vilja lägga till när det gäller kommuner och EU:s offentliga samråd?
- Är det något du skulle vilja fråga om när det gäller denna studie?

9.2 Interview guide in English

1. Introduction and Warm-up

- Thank you for taking the time to participate. Before we begin, could you briefly describe your current role in the municipality?
- In what way, if any, are EU-related issues part of your work?

2. Main Questions

- Has your municipality ever participated in an EU consultation?
- Follow-up if yes: When was the last time you participated, and what led to your participation on that occasion?
- Follow-up if no: What is the reason for that?

2.1 Willingness

- How do you view EU consultations compared to other channels of influence, for example through SKR or municipal membership organizations such as Eurocities?
- How do you assess the potential impact of responding to EU consultations?
- Follow-up if they do not respond to consultations: Under what circumstances would participation in EU consultations feel meaningful or worth the time?
- Follow-up if they respond sometimes/often: What makes participation in EU consultations feel meaningful or worth the time?
- How is participation in EU consultations prioritised within the organisation?

2.1 Understanding

- Do you feel that there are any expectations for municipalities to participate in EU consultations? (from EU institutions, national authorities/government, interest organizations or networks, political expectations locally/within your own organization)
- Follow-up if yes: Could you describe those expectations?

- Follow-up if no: Do you perceive any other expectations regarding how municipalities should act in relation to EU decision-making? (e.g., contributing local knowledge, implementing EU legislation, representing local interests, cooperating in European networks, etc.)
- Do you perceive it as a municipal responsibility to respond to EU consultations (i.e., do you see it as one of the municipality's inherent tasks)?

2.3 Capacity

- Do you feel there are any factors that make it easier or more difficult for the municipality to participate in EU consultations? Which ones?
- How would you describe the municipality's resources for working with EU public consultations?
- How would you describe the municipality's competencies when it comes to working with EU public consultations?

3. Concluding Reflection

- Is there anything you would like to add regarding municipalities and EU public consultations?
- Is there anything you would like to ask about regarding this study?